MODULE 02 · CASE STUDY 9 · PRE-READ FOR CLASS 9

Two Cases: The Road and the Garage

Standing at the Side of the Road, Bangalore 2010 · Four Friends in a Garage, Girgaon 1942

READ THIS BEFORE CLASS

Two companies, seventy years apart, in businesses that have nothing to do with each other. Read both. They are in one document because of something they do not share, and finding it is the work of the next session.

Read this once for the story and a second time with a pencil. On the second pass, keep two lists: everything the customer in these pages is trying to get *away from*, and everything they are trying to get *towards*. Bring both lists. Nothing to memorise, no definitions, no frameworks.

30–40	2	8
Minutes to read	Cases	Questions to bring

Zenith School of AI · Customer Discovery · Semester 1

CASE A

Standing at the Side of the Road

Bangalore, 2010: six kilometres away in forty minutes, no app on your phone, and your hand in the air

READING TIME: 15–20 minutes

HOW TO READ THIS CASE

If you were born after about 2005 you may never have stood at the side of a road bargaining for a ride. Before class, ask a parent or an older cousin what it used to be like, and listen to how they tell it — which part they get annoyed about, and which part they laugh about. Their answer will be more useful to you in the room than anything on this page.

As you read the first section, resist the urge to treat it as one bad afternoon. Break it into its parts and count them.

1 One Ride, in 2010

You have to be somewhere six kilometres away in forty minutes. There is no app on your phone, because in 2010 there is no app for this. What you do is walk to the edge of the road and raise your hand.

Three auto-rickshaws pass without slowing down. The fourth one stops. You say the name of the place. The driver tilts his head, says nothing, and drives off. The fifth stops, hears the destination, and says a number — and the number is roughly double what the meter would have read if he had agreed to use the meter, which he has not. You argue. He shrugs and starts to move. You say yes, because you have twenty-eight minutes left and the sun is directly overhead.

On the way he stops for fuel with you sitting in the back. At the destination you hand over the note and he does not have change, so the fare quietly rises again by ten rupees. You get out. You have no idea who that man was, what vehicle you were in, or whom you would tell if something had gone wrong.

Now do something a business analyst does and an ordinary passenger never does. Stop treating that as one bad experience, and break it into separate things that went wrong. There are at least six of them in those three paragraphs.

You did not know whether a ride was coming at all, or when. You did not know what it would cost until you were already standing in the middle of a negotiation you were losing. You could be refused for reasons never explained to you. The fare moved after the ride was over, because of change. Nobody knew where you were or with whom. And the last one, which almost never appears on anybody's list of complaints: you had that entire argument standing on a public road, sometimes in front of your mother, sometimes in front of a colleague, sometimes in front of a girl you were trying to impress, and you lost it in front of them.

WORTH PAUSING ON

> Six things, and they are not all the same kind of thing. Some of them cost you money or minutes. Some of them cost you something else entirely. Before you read on, sort the six into groups of your own making and be ready to defend your groups, including the group you had to invent for the last one.
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> Then notice something about the whole list, and hold on to it: every single item on it is something the customer wants to get *away* from. Not one of them is a thing the customer wants.

2 Bhavish Aggarwal, a Rented Car, and the Road to Bandipur

Bhavish Aggarwal finished a B.Tech in computer science at IIT Bombay in 2008 and joined Microsoft Research in Bangalore, where he spent two years, filed two patents and published three research papers. That is a description of somebody set up for a long and comfortable career in a research lab. He left it to sell weekend trips.

The business was called Olatrip.com and it did what dozens of small sites did at the time: holiday packages and weekend getaways, booked online, for people in Bangalore who wanted to leave the city on a Friday evening. Bhavish was, in effect, a travel agent with a website.

Then came the trip that everybody who tells this story tells. He rented a car to go from Bangalore to Bandipur, a forest reserve about five and a half hours away. Somewhere in the middle of the journey the driver stopped the car and said the agreed fare was no longer the fare. Bhavish refused to renegotiate. The driver left him at the side of the road, in the middle of the trip, and drove away.

Notice what he did with that. The obvious reaction is anger at one driver. The reaction he had was different: if this can happen to me, on a booking I made and paid for, then the thing I am selling is not actually a service. It is a hope. He was not in the transport business at all. He was reselling other people's unreliability and taking a commission on it.

It is worth knowing what already existed, because 'there was nothing' is almost never true. Radio taxi companies had been operating in Indian cities since about 2006 and 2007, Meru Cabs in Mumbai being the best known, with metered fares, printed receipts and a call centre. They were a real improvement and not a small one. They were also expensive, thin on the ground, and something you booked hours in advance for an airport run rather than something you used to get across town. What had not been addressed was the ordinary six-kilometre trip that somebody needed in the next four minutes, which is where almost all the volume was.

Olacabs was incorporated on 3 December 2010. Ankit Bhati, also from IIT Bombay, a B.Tech in mechanical engineering and an M.Tech in computer-aided design and automation, joined that November and built the technology. The founding team was six people. In April 2011 they raised an angel round of about US$330,000 from Kunal Bahl, who had founded Snapdeal, along with Anupam Mittal and Rehan Yar Khan. In the early months Bhavish personally answered the phone when customers called to book, because there was nobody else to answer it, and because it is very hard to misunderstand a customer whose voice you are listening to.

Ola did not begin with a technology insight, and it did not begin with a market-size spreadsheet. It began with a list: a specific, itemised, unglamorous list of things that were wrong, most of which the founder had personally suffered.

3 Reading the Product as a Reply

Take the six problems from Section 1 and read Ola's early product against each one, in order. This is not a reconstruction invented afterwards to make the story neat. It is how the features line up.

You did not know whether a ride was coming. Ola put a map on your screen with a car on it, moving towards you, with a number of minutes attached. The car was always going to arrive. What changed was that you could watch it arrive — an unbounded wait became a bounded one.

You did not know what it would cost. Ola showed a fare before you booked. This is a much larger decision than it looks, because a company that quotes a price up front has taken the risk of traffic and detours onto its own books instead of leaving it on the customer's. It is expensive to do and it removes an entire category of argument.

You could be refused. On the app the driver accepts the trip before knowing very much about it, and cancelling has a cost attached. The refusal did not become impossible. It became expensive for the person doing the refusing, which is the only durable way to change behaviour at scale.

The fare moved at the end. Cashless payment closed that. No change, no note, no rounding up, no negotiation on the pavement after the ride was over.

Nobody knew where you were. The app produced a driver's name, his photograph, the vehicle registration number, and a trip you could share with somebody who was not in the car. None of this makes a journey physically safer. It makes it recorded, and being recorded changes what people do.

And the argument in public. This one Ola never mentioned in a single advertisement. The price was agreed by a machine before anybody arrived. There was nothing left to argue about, so nobody watched you argue.

Six items, six answers. Not a mood and not a slogan about convenience, but a numbered list of injuries with a mechanism aimed at each one.

4 Three Things That Were Not the Absence of Anything

If removing those six were the whole story, the ride-hailing app would have been a utility: useful, unloved, and switched the moment something cheaper appeared. Something else was happening as well, and it is harder to see because it does not correspond to any complaint.

The first was control. Watching a car come towards you on a map is not the removal of a wait. People check the moving dot far more often than the information justifies. If it were only information, they would look once.

The second was a kind of standing. For a very large number of Indians, the first time they got into a booked cab with their name on the trip was the first time they had been treated as a customer rather than as a supplicant on a road. Nobody would ever have put that on a list of complaints, because you cannot complain about the absence of something you have never had.

The third was small and social. Arriving somewhere in a cab said something slightly different about you than arriving after an argument with an auto driver. Ola did not invent that difference, and it was careful never to say it out loud, but a great deal of early adoption ran on it.

> **HOLD THIS THOUGHT**
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> None of those three appears anywhere on the list of six from Section 1, and no customer in 2010 would have named any of them if you had asked. Work out, before class, how a company is supposed to find things like this — given that asking clearly does not produce them.

5 The Part Most Retellings Skip

Having built its brand on the failures of the auto-rickshaw, Ola launched Ola Auto and put the auto-rickshaw itself on the app.

If your reading of this case has been 'autos are the problem, cabs are the solution', that move makes no sense at all. Sit with it. The class opens on exactly this, and the answer is somewhere in the list of six.

One honest number to end on, because a case study that reports only triumph is not a case study. Ola's mobility business reported revenue of about ₹2,844 crore in FY20 and roughly ₹2,800 crore in FY24 — four years later, at about the same level, after a pandemic, aggressive competition from Uber and rapid expansion elsewhere in the group. A November 2024 fundraise valued the mobility business at around US$2 billion, well below its peak.

Removing those six injuries moved tens of millions of Indians in a handful of years. It did not, on its own, build a position that nobody could attack. Decide for yourself what is missing, and then read Case B.

6 The Question Case A Sets Up

Ola built its brand on how bad auto-rickshaws were, and then put auto-rickshaws on its own app.

How does that make any sense? Come with an answer. The good answers all involve going back to the list of six and noticing something about all of them at once.

CASE B

Four Friends in a Garage

Girgaon, Bombay, 1942: a war that stopped imports, and eighty years spent on the half of the picture Case A never reaches

READING TIME: 15–20 minutes

HOW TO READ THIS CASE

Paint looks like a product business. Read it as something else. Almost nothing in this case is about paint, and the parts that appear to be about paint — a tinting machine, a certified applicator — are there for reasons that have nothing to do with the chemistry.

Keep your two lists running. Away from, and towards. This company worked on both for eighty years, and the second list is much longer here than it was in Case A.

1 February 1942, Gaiwadi, Girgaon

Four friends — Champaklal Choksey, Chimanlal Choksi, Suryakant Dani and Arvind Vakil — started making paint in a garage in Gaiwadi, Girgaon, in what was then Bombay. The Second World War had restricted imports, and the foreign paint companies serving India were short of stock.

By 1967 the company they built, Asian Paints, was the largest paint manufacturer in the country. In FY24 it reported consolidated revenue of ₹35,382 crore, sells through more than 1.6 lakh retail touchpoints, and holds roughly half of India's decorative paint market — a share now under real attack from new entrants.

2 What Is Actually Wrong With Painting a House

Start with the things a customer wants to get away from, and notice that they have almost nothing to do with paint.

Repainting a house means furniture in the middle of the room for four days, and dust on everything. It means strangers walking through your home while your family is in it. You choose a colour from a chip two inches wide, and you find out whether you were right only after an entire wall is that colour and the money has been spent. You cannot judge the quality of what is being applied, so you cannot tell whether the contractor used what you paid for. And there is the small, constant worry that you are being overcharged by somebody who knows more than you do: about quantity, about grade, about how many coats a wall really needs.

Read that list next to the list of six from Case A. They are different injuries in a different decade, but a surprising amount of the shape is the same. Mark the items that match.

3 The Thing Nobody Wants Paint For

Nobody wants paint. What they want is to bring somebody home and watch that person look around.

Asian Paints understood this early enough to build an entire advertising history on it rather than on durability or coverage. The long-running line *Har Ghar Kuch Kehta Hai* — every home says something — is a statement about the owner, not about the coating. Gattu, the mischievous boy with a paint bucket drawn by the cartoonist R. K. Laxman in 1954, did the same job in a different decade: he made a chemical product feel like it belonged to an ordinary family.

It would be easy to file all of that under advertising and move on. Do not, because the more interesting half is what happened in operations.

4 Not Advertising, Operations

Tinting machines in the dealer's shop, rolled out from the late 1990s onward, let a small dealer offer thousands of shades mixed in front of the customer instead of stocking a few dozen tins. Look carefully at what that single machine does at both ends. It frees a dealer from money tied up in slow-moving inventory, and it gives a customer the exact shade she imagined, made while she watches.

The Safe Painting Service put trained, certified applicators with hygiene and quality protocols into your house. Read that against the list in Section 2 and mark which two items it is aimed at.

Beautiful Homes, launched as a personalised interior design service in 2020, sells the finished feeling directly, with the paint as a component of it rather than as the thing being bought.

> **WORTH PAUSING ON**
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> Ola's six mechanisms and Asian Paints' three are doing different kinds of work, and the difference is the entire reason these two cases are in one document. Before the questions page, try to write the difference in one sentence that does not use the word 'better'.
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> Then a harder one. Ola's list came from a founder who had personally suffered every item on it. Where could Asian Paints possibly have got its list from, given that nobody in 1954 was complaining about not being able to make their house say something?

5 The Question Case B Sets Up

Ola built itself in a handful of years by removing six specific injuries, and four years of revenue later sits at roughly where it was. Asian Paints spent eighty years on something else as well, and holds half its market at ₹35,382 crore.

Neither one is the complete answer, and the class is not a vote between them. The question is this: **if you interviewed a hundred customers carefully, which of the two lists would you come back with — and what would you have to do differently to come back with the other one?**

BEFORE YOU COME TO CLASS

> **HOW TO USE THIS PAGE**
>
> Four questions per case. Spend twenty-five minutes on the set and write your answers down, a line or two each. They will not be collected or graded, but you will be asked for them out loud, and 'I didn't think about it' is a much worse position to be in than a wrong answer.
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> There are no model answers at the back of this document. That is deliberate.

On the Road

1. **Bring your sorted list of the six.** Whatever groups you made, bring them, and bring the group you had to invent for the argument in public. Then say which of the six you would have fixed first if you could only fix one, and what that choice costs you.

2. **Ask a parent or an older relative about auto-rickshaws before 2012.** Write down one sentence of what they actually said, in their words. Notice whether they told you about the money or about something else.

3. **People check the moving dot far more often than the information justifies.** Name one screen in your own phone that you open more often than the information on it deserves. Then say what you are actually getting from it.

4. **Ola Auto.** Make the argument that launching it was a betrayal of everything the brand was built on. Then make the argument that it was the most consistent thing the company ever did. Decide which one you believe before you arrive.

On the Garage

5. **Take the list from Section 2 of Case B and rank it.** Which one would actually stop a family from repainting this year? Be honest about the difference between what annoys people and what stops them.

6. **Gattu and 'Har Ghar Kuch Kehta Hai' are seventy and thirty years old respectively.** A new paint company launching tomorrow cannot buy either of them. Say what it would have to do instead, and roughly how long you think it would take.

7. **Take your own home, or your hostel room.** Name one thing in it you own that you would not replace with a cheaper, identical-performing version. Say why, out loud, in a sentence you would be willing to read to the room.

8. **Make the case against Asian Paints.** It holds half a market and its share is now under attack from new entrants with lower prices. Say what, if anything, eighty years of this work is actually protecting.

Come with your eight answers, both lists, and one genuine disagreement. If some part of either case struck you as unfair to the auto driver, or too admiring of a very large company, say so out loud. Those are usually the most useful ten minutes of the class.